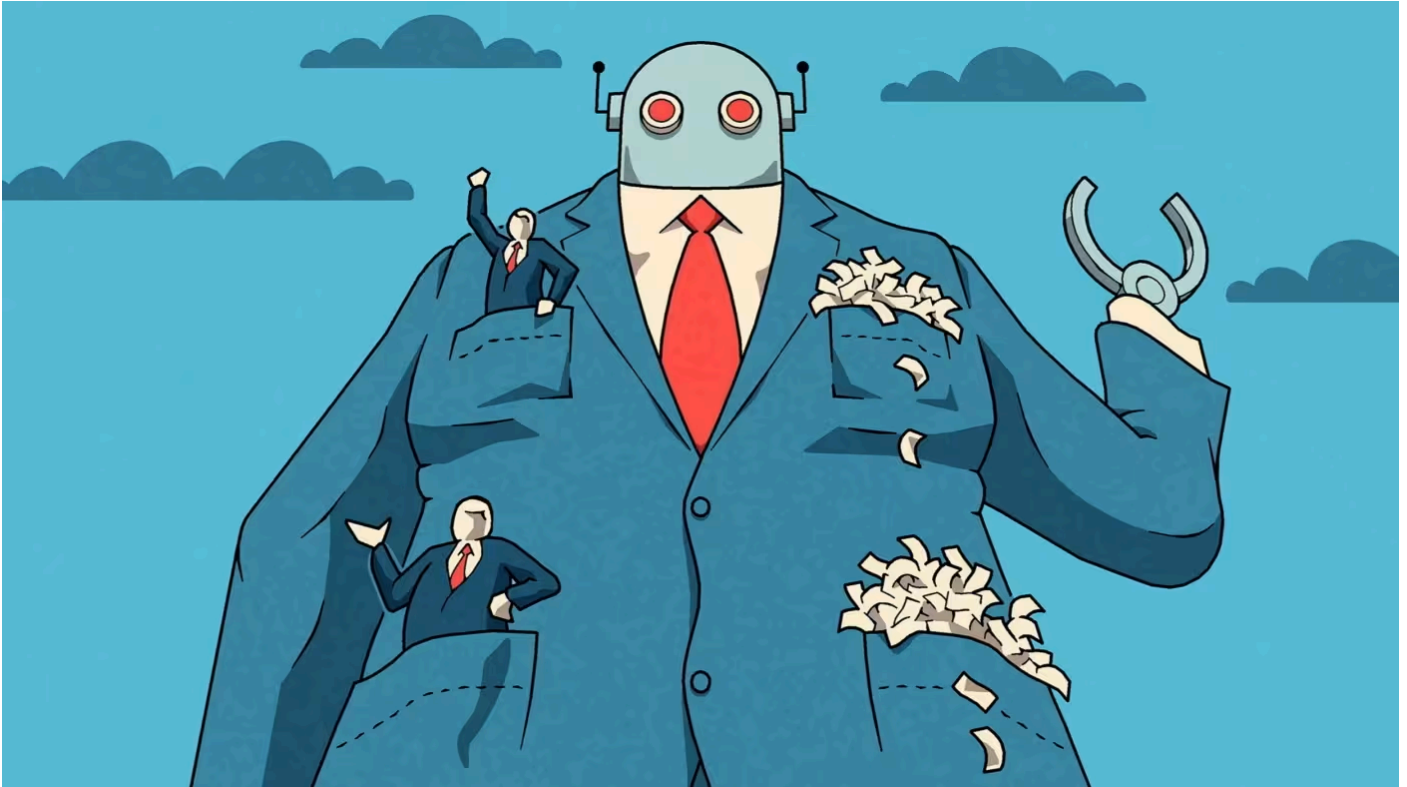


Protecting Big Tech, not free speech

Trump and Farage are using censorship as a cloak for disinformation

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Big tech firms will get into bed with pretty much anyone willing to push back against regulation that threatens their business model, which thrives on the most extreme viral content. Silicon Valley's sycophantic support of Donald Trump is a case in point.

But last week, Americans got a unique look at one of Big Tech's most vociferous defenders abroad. Nigel Farage, the head of Britain's rightwing populist Reform party, appeared at the House Judiciary Committee meeting to warn Americans of the dangers of the UK's Online Safety Act, which he improbably claims is turning Britain — which Reporters Without Borders ranks among the top 20 countries for protecting freedom of speech — into a censorship state akin to North Korea.

Farage argued that the act, which is basically about keeping child porn and violent political extremism off the net, “will damage trade between our countries, threaten free speech across the west because of the knock-on rollout effects of this legislation from us or from the European Union” and even get Americans travelling to the UK thrown in jail. “It is a potentially big threat to tech bosses [and] to many, many others,” he claims.

It’s hard to see Farage, who once expressed admiration for Vladimir Putin and who has publicly criticised pro-Gaza protests in the UK, as a beacon of liberalism. But you can give him credit for being worried about America’s tech oligarchs. His aims and theirs align quite nicely. Rightwing populists all over Europe want to destroy the ability of the UK and the EU to regulate large tech platforms — a move that might threaten their disinformation campaigns with genuine political debate.

Trump and his administration want to aid those allies while propping up the Big Tech companies that power America’s frothy stock market. If the markets crash, he’s done too.

These two aims reach their apex in the administration’s crusade against Europe’s Digital Services Act which, like the Online Safety Act, aims to curb politician extremism, crime and fraud online. This past July, House Republicans issued a report entitled, “The Foreign Censorship Threat: How the European Union’s Digital Services Act Compels Global Censorship and Infringes on American Free Speech”. The document has several talking points that remind me of what I’ve heard over the past 20 years from technology lobbyists looking to use the first amendment as a way to shield themselves from any responsibility for the harms caused by their business model.

The report has a spate of misleading examples about how the DSA works, which prompted outcries from a number of academics and civil society groups in both the US and Europe. Jamie Raskin, the ranking Democratic member of the House Judiciary Committee, put out a document correcting the misstatements, including the notion that Russian election interference is a myth (it’s not), and that the DSA will kill political debate in Europe (the DSA’s actions against illegal content account for less than 0.001 per cent of what’s taken down; in fact, most moderation is done willingly by platforms themselves). Dozens of leading academics also sent a [letter](#) to House leaders defending the DSA and debunking claims that it is a tool for censorship.

Raskin, who eviscerated Farage in the House Judiciary session last week, pointing out his various hypocrisies and flip flops on the issue, noted that “Donald Trump and Mr Farage both claim they’re protectors of free speech, but they only want to protect speech they agree with”. (Fair enough: remember that Republicans at large and Trump himself were constantly bashing Big Tech during the Obama and Biden years when it appeared more aligned with Democratic interests.)

When I asked Raskin by phone whether he is more worried about rightwing populism in the US and Europe, or the power of Big Tech oligarchs, he replied, “It’s not an either/or proposition. While the motor force behind the ‘free speech’ campaign is the large US technology firms [and their lobbyists], the issue is being exploited by Trump, Farage and other rightwingers,” who want to divide Americans and Europeans alike.

The solution, says Raskin, is “transnational democratic solidarity”. He wants people from all parties and countries who believe in democratic norms to work together, given that Trump and the tech titans are waging a global battle to allow American platforms to dominate. Witness Trump’s August instructions to US diplomats in Europe to build an opposition campaign to the DSA in their individual countries, and secretary of state Marco Rubio’s threats to ban visas for those who “censor” speech by Americans.

Of course, the clearest messages always come from the horse’s mouth. In a social media post on August 25, Trump threatened higher tariffs on any country that dares to regulate Big Tech. “I will stand up to Countries that attack our incredible American Tech Companies. Digital Taxes, Digital Services Legislation, and Digital Markets Regulations are all designed to harm, or discriminate against, American Technology . . . American Technology Companies, are neither the ‘piggy bank’ nor the ‘doormat’ of the World any longer. Show respect to America and our amazing Tech Companies or, consider the consequences!”

Not a word here on free speech, but plenty on protecting Big Tech profits.

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